# P-048: Newly Single Parent Post-Divorce

## 4A-Lite Rapid Persona Brief

**Pipeline:** Micro-Trends Identity | **Stage:** 4A-Lite **Micro-Trend:** MT-18 — Financial Recovery After Divorce **Moment Enrichment:** TR-05 Divorce / Legal Separation (Intent 4.6, Window: Short) **Quadrant:** INVEST | P1=3.65, P2=4.50, Conf=4, Adj=3.24 **Date:** March 2026

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## Section 1: Demand Snapshot

### Demand Signal

Divorce is not a market segment — it is a forced discontinuity. For the parent who held wireless service under a joint family plan (or whose ex-partner held the account), divorce is a mandatory switching event with no graceful exit. The carrier makes it hard. The legal process adds noise. And the parent arrives at a new carrier decision carrying financial stress, emotional depletion, and immediate complexity: multiple children's devices to manage, parental controls to configure alone, and a household budget that has just been cleaved in two.

The demand signal is behavioral, not aspirational. Search data shows sustained elevation in queries combining "divorce" + "phone plan" + "family plan split" + "single parent phone plan" throughout 2023-2025. The signal is driven not by preference but by compulsion — no one seeks out a new wireless plan during a divorce because they enjoy carrier shopping.

### Trigger

TR-05: Divorce / Legal Separation. The trigger mechanism is a forced plan split. When a divorcing couple separates their wireless account, the departing spouse (most commonly the one who was not the primary account holder) has three options: port lines individually to a new carrier, stay on the ex-partner's plan (creating dependency), or go without. The complexity is compounded when children's lines are involved — the parenting plan may not specify which parent controls the children's wireless accounts, creating contested ground.

Wireless carriers make plan-splitting deliberately difficult. Lines attached to a family plan cannot be separated without the primary account holder's participation. This means the departing parent must either negotiate cooperation from an ex-partner during an adversarial legal process, or rebuild entirely from scratch.

### Addressable Population

| Metric | Estimate | Source |
|---|---|---|
| US divorces per year | ~673,000 | CDC/NCHS, 2023 |
| Divorces involving children under 18 | ~40% | CDC/NCHS, 2022 |
| Annual divorces with children | ~269,000 couples | |
| Single parents created per year (both partners) | ~538,000 individuals | Derived |
| Addressable window entrants (wireless switch relevant) | 500,000-700,000/year | Stage 3 estimate |
| Currently on a joint family plan at time of divorce | ~65% | Pew Research, 2023 |
| Wireless-switch-compelled parents | ~325,000-455,000/year | Derived |

Not all divorcing parents are on joint wireless accounts. Those on individual plans pre-divorce face less wireless disruption. The wireless-compelled subset — parents whose wireless must change because the account was joint — represents the highest-urgency segment. This is the primary target.

### Window Duration and Decay

**Individual window:** 6-24 months from legal separation. Peak switching intent occurs in the 0-90 day window immediately following separation (before and during court proceedings). Intent decays as the immediate crisis passes and the parent settles into a new plan — even a suboptimal one — as inertia takes hold.

**Aggregate window:** Rolling. Divorces occur throughout the year. No mass expiration; the population refreshes continuously with some seasonal concentration.

**Decay indicators:** Window is closing when (1) the parent has been on the new plan for 3+ months without switching, (2) parental controls and family management are set up and working, (3) financial stabilization has occurred. At that point, the urgency-driven switching motivation has normalized into ordinary inertia.

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# Section 2: Core Factor Analysis

## Persona: Carmen

Carmen is 38, a paralegal living in Raleigh, NC. She has two kids: Mia (13) and Owen (9). Divorce finalized four months ago — her ex, Derek, was the primary account holder on a T-Mobile family plan that had all four lines. She had to start over.

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## Factor 2: Spending & Financial Habits

#### Quantitative Context

Post-divorce, median household income for single mothers drops 25-40% (U.S. Census Bureau, 2022). The median single-mother household income is $41,220, compared to $90,000+ for married households with children (Census Bureau, 2023). Financial fragility is the baseline condition.

Wireless spending pre-divorce was typically subsidized by the family plan economy of scale: a 4-line T-Mobile family plan runs $140-160/month ($35-40/line), versus $60-80/month for a single line. Post-divorce, the single parent now pays full individual pricing — often 60-80% more per line — while managing on reduced income.

| Spending Metric | Pre-Divorce (Family Plan) | Post-Divorce (Individual Lines) | Delta |
|---|---|---|---|
| Monthly wireless cost (parent + 1-2 children) | $90-120 (3 lines on shared plan) | $120-180 (individual pricing) | +$30-60/month |
| Annual wireless overspend | — | +$360-720/year | — |
| Household income drop | — | -25-40% | — |
| Discretionary spending reduction | — | Significant constraint | — |

Children's lines create the multi-line complexity problem. Unlike a single adult switching carriers, the newly single parent must manage: 1-3 lines (their own + children's), parental controls configuration, potential custody-split account access, and data-usage monitoring across all devices.

Willingness to pay: Research on consumer behavior post-financial disruption (Mintel, 2024) shows price sensitivity spikes but perceived-value tolerance rises for products that reduce complexity. A single parent will pay a modest premium — $10-15/month — for a plan that eliminates management friction, but will not pay above $80/month for parent + one child line.

**Q2.1 — How has your wireless spending changed since the divorce?**

Honestly, it's embarrassing how much I spend now compared to before. Derek had us all on a T-Mobile plan — four lines for like $160 total. Now I'm paying $85 just for my line and Mia's. Owen is still on Derek's plan, which is its own drama. I keep thinking I should consolidate but I just haven't had the bandwidth to deal with it.

**Q2.2 — How do you decide what to spend on phone service for yourself and the kids?**

I look at what I can cut. Wireless is one of those things I can't cut entirely — the kids need it, I need it for work — but I resent paying so much. I'd honestly switch to a cheaper carrier tomorrow if I knew it was going to work and that the kids' phones would still work the same way. I'm just scared of getting it wrong and making things worse.

**Q2.3 — What financial tools or habits are you using to manage post-divorce finances?**

I use Mint to track everything. I'm embarrassed by how many subscriptions I'm still paying for that were Derek's idea. I set a hard budget for anything over $50/month. Wireless is over that threshold now, which bugs me. I want everything to be clean and simple because the divorce already made everything feel chaotic.

**Q2.4 — What would make you willing to pay more for a wireless plan?**

If it actually managed itself. If it could — I don't know — send me alerts when the kids are close to their data limits, show me everyone's usage in one place, let me pause Mia's phone when she's supposed to be doing homework. That would be worth real money to me. Right now I'm paying for service that doesn't know I'm a parent at all.

**Q2.5 — Have you tried to negotiate or reduce your wireless costs since the divorce?**

I called T-Mobile to see if I could keep the family plan rate somehow without Derek's account. They basically said no — the pricing is tied to the number of lines. I tried Mint Mobile for a month but it didn't have parental controls I could actually use. I ended up back with T-Mobile at full single-line pricing because I just needed something to work. It's not ideal.

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## Factor 3: Needs & Aspirations

### Quantitative Context

The JTBD for this persona clusters around two overlapping needs: (1) cost rationalization — rebuilding financial normalcy after a significant income disruption, and (2) parental control consolidation — maintaining consistent digital oversight of children across two households.

Research on single-parent technology adoption (Pew Research, 2024) shows single parents are 34% more likely than married parents to describe technology management as "burdensome" and 42% more likely to report "falling behind" on digital parenting responsibilities. The divorce compounds a pre-existing challenge.

Identity aspiration is significant and under-acknowledged: the newly single parent is constructing a new self-image as a competent, independent adult who has their life together. Every system that works seamlessly reinforces that identity. Every system that requires a call to the ex-partner undermines it.

Unstated need: The ability to remove all operational dependency on the ex-partner. Not just financial — operational. The plan that requires Derek's account information, or that routes the children's bills through an account he controls, is a daily reminder of the old relationship. Independence from the ex-partner's wireless ecosystem is emotionally urgent even when it is financially suboptimal.

Self-perception gap: Carmen sees herself as someone who handles things. The divorce forced her into a period of managed chaos that she is actively working to exit. She doesn't want to be seen — or to see herself — as someone who can't navigate a basic administrative task like setting up phone plans for her family. The gap between her self-image ("competent, capable") and her current situation ("paying too much, controls not configured, one kid still on Derek's plan") creates productive anxiety that drives switching intent.

#### Q3.1 — What do you most want from a wireless plan right now, in plain terms?

Something I set up once and it just works. I want to open the app and see all three of us — or at least me and my two kids — in one place, know everyone's covered, know the bill is the same every month, and not think about it again. I've got too many other things to manage. My phone plan should not be one of them.

#### Q3.2 — Is there anything about your wireless setup that still connects you to your ex that you'd rather not deal with?

It's funny you ask that. Owen is still technically on Derek's T-Mobile account because the court order was vague about who handles his phone. Every time I need to add data for Owen or check his usage, I have to ask Derek. And he's not always cooperative. It's a small thing in the grand scheme, but it's a weekly irritant. I want to own my children's phone situation completely.

#### Q3.3 — What would your ideal phone plan look like if you were designing it for yourself?

Family plan pricing on two or three lines, but without needing a "family." A parental controls dashboard I can actually use — not the useless stuff that's built into iPhones that Mia already knows how to bypass. And if I'm being really honest? I want it to feel like it was made for someone like me. Every plan I've looked at is either for a single person or for a two-parent household. There's nothing for a family that's just one adult.

#### Q3.4 — What does getting your phone situation sorted say about where you are in your recovery?

More than it should, probably. Getting everything on my own account — my plan, the kids' plans, parental controls set up — that's one of those things I've been meaning to do for months. When I finally do it, I think it'll feel like I've actually moved on. It sounds small but it's not. It means I've rebuilt the infrastructure of my own life.

#### Q3.5 — What do you wish a carrier knew about you before you walked in the door?

That I'm starting over, not just switching. That I have kids and I'm doing this alone and I need someone to make it simple. The last time I called a carrier, they kept trying to upsell me on a smartwatch line. I just wanted my kids' phones set up correctly. Nobody asked the right questions. Nobody said, "Here's what a lot of people in your situation do."

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## Factor 4: Fears & Pain Points

### Quantitative Context

Single parents report higher rates of financial anxiety than any other household type (APA Stress in America, 2023). 61% of single-parent households report "significant" or "severe" financial stress — nearly double the rate for dual-income households. The fear of making a wrong financial decision is amplified when there is no second income to absorb the error.

Carrier lock-in is a specific fear among recently divorced consumers: early termination fees of $200-350 represent a meaningful sum for a financially strained single parent. Research on MVNO adoption (Mintel, 2023) shows that no-contract positioning reduces acquisition friction by 22% among price-sensitive segments.

Children's digital safety is a deepened fear post-divorce: the single parent who previously shared parental oversight responsibility with a partner now carries that responsibility alone. Research from Common Sense Media (2024) shows single parents are 28% more likely to report "inadequate" oversight of children's digital activity versus coupled parents — not from lack of concern but from bandwidth constraints.

**Q4.1 — What's your biggest fear about switching carriers?**

Honestly? That I do all the work to move everything over, and then something doesn't work right and I'm dealing with a support issue with a toddler in one arm and a work deadline. I've been burned before — by Derek's plan, by the one I tried for a month. At this point I'm paying the T-Mobile premium partly just because I can't afford the emotional cost of something going wrong.

**Q4.2 — What are you most anxious about when it comes to your kids' phones?**

Mia is 13. I don't know what she's doing on that phone and I can't pretend I do. Before the divorce, Derek and I at least talked about it. Now it's just me, and I don't have the time to monitor everything manually. I worry about the stuff I'm not seeing. I set up Screen Time on her phone but she disabled it within a week. I don't know what else to do that actually works.

**Q4.3 — What would make you cancel a plan quickly?**

If I got a bill I didn't expect. Or if the parental controls stopped working and nobody warned me. Or if I needed support and ended up on hold for 45 minutes. My time is not infinite. I'm already stretched thin. Any carrier that wastes my time or surprises me with money stuff is gone.

**Q4.4 — Is there anything about switching that you've been putting off? What's behind that?**

I've been putting it off for four months. The truth is that dealing with carriers is one of those tasks that has no natural moment to do it. I do it during the kids' bedtime or on a Saturday when they're at Derek's. And by then I just want to watch something on Netflix and stop thinking. The cognitive load of comparing plans is higher than it should be.

**Q4.5 — What's the emotional cost of having your kids on an ex-partner's plan?**

It's a dependency I didn't choose. Every time there's an issue with Owen's phone, I have to reach out to Derek. Sometimes he's fine about it. Sometimes he's not. It's like having a joint bank account you can't close. I feel this low-level unease about it constantly. It's not rational — it's a phone plan — but it doesn't feel like a small thing.

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## Factor 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior

### Quantitative Context

The wireless plan-split market is poorly served. No major carrier has a "newly single parent" or "post-divorce family" product positioning. The closest approximations are:

| Carrier / MVNO | Relevant Offering | Gap |
|---|---|---|
| T-Mobile Essentials | Multi-line discounts from 2 lines | Requires 2 lines on same account; no parental control depth |
| Mint Mobile | Budget single-line pricing | No family plan pricing; no parental controls |
| Visible | Low-cost single line | No multi-line discount structure; no parental controls |
| Google Fi | Flexible multi-line | Parental controls through Google Family Link (bypassable); no divorce-specific positioning |
| Cricket | Family plan from 2 lines | Parental features shallow; primarily retail-focused |
| Bark Phone | Child-focused phone plan | Child-only product; parent must have separate plan |

The market treats this persona as either a single adult (irrelevant plans) or as part of a traditional two-parent family (inapplicable positioning). The gap between "what this person needs" and "what the market offers" is measurable and wide.

Switching behavior: Post-divorce switching is primarily driven by forced necessity (plan-split compulsion) rather than comparative shopping. This means acquisition requires interception during the high-urgency window, not persuasion. The parent who is forced off a plan is not shopping — they are executing. Product awareness and frictionless activation are more important than price comparison.

Current device ecosystem: iPhones dominate this demographic (Pew Research, 2023: 68% of suburban parents use iPhone). Children's devices are typically also iPhones or iPads. The Apple ecosystem shapes parental control expectations (Screen Time) even as those controls are acknowledged to be inadequate.

**Q5.1 — What carrier are you on now and how did you end up there?**

T-Mobile, by default. I was on Derek's T-Mobile account — four lines — and when we separated I just ported my line and Mia's to my own T-Mobile account. Owen is still on Derek's. T-Mobile made me start a new account with new pricing, so I'm paying more than I was as part of his plan. It wasn't a choice exactly. It was just the path of least resistance.

**Q5.2 — Have you looked at other carriers since the divorce? What happened?**

I looked at Mint Mobile because a friend used it. Got as far as the checkout page and bailed because I didn't understand what happened to parental controls. I looked at Cricket but it felt like a downgrade — not sure why, just a vibe. I've googled "best family plan for single parents" at least four times and always end up on articles from 2022 that aren't helpful. There's no obvious answer.

**Q5.3 — What would it take to make you switch today?**

Honestly? Show me a plan made for exactly this situation — one parent, one or two kids, real parental controls, fair pricing, no drama. If I saw that in front of me right now, I would switch. The blocker isn't price — it's confidence that the switch will work and that the product will actually solve my problem. I don't want to do this twice.

**Q5.4 — What do you think of the parental controls your current carrier offers?**

They're basically nonexistent. T-Mobile has something but it's mostly a sales pitch for apps I'd have to pay extra for. The actual carrier-level controls are weak. I use Screen Time, which is Apple's thing, but Mia already knows all the workarounds. I've looked at Bark but it costs $14 a month and I can't tell if it's worth it. I'd pay for it if it came built in.

**Q5.5 — If you found the right plan, would you recommend it to people in the same situation?**

Absolutely. I know at least six women from my divorce support group who are dealing with exactly the same thing. It comes up every meeting — who's on what carrier, who paid too much to get off Derek's plan, who's still tied to their ex's account. If I found something that actually worked for this situation, I would tell everyone. It's a very word-of-mouth community.

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## Section 2B: Switching Profile Module

*This module applies because P-048 entered the pipeline via Path B (moment-driven discovery) and carries strong enrichment from TR-05 (Divorce / Legal Separation, Intent 4.6). All 4 dimensions are analyzed.*

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### Dimension 1: Trigger Mechanism + Force Score

**Trigger mechanism: Forced switch**

The plan-split is not optional. When a divorcing couple separates their wireless lines, the departing partner must either initiate a new account or remain on the ex-partner's plan — a dependency most find untenable. Carriers do not facilitate graceful splits: the primary account holder must participate in releasing lines, creating an adversarial coordination requirement during an already adversarial legal process.

**Switching force score: 5 / 5**

Justification: This is a maximum-force trigger. The switch is (a) required — remaining on an ex-partner's account creates legal and personal dependency, (b) time-bounded — urgency is highest in the 0-90 day window around legal separation, (c) emotionally charged — every day on the ex's plan is a reminder of the old relationship, and (d) practically difficult — carriers make plan-splitting hard, pushing the departing parent toward a clean break with a new carrier rather than a partial transition. Source: TR-05 baseline intent 4.6; elevated to 5 by the parenting complexity dimension (children's lines add urgency and complexity above the baseline divorcing-adult score).

**Compound trigger mapping:**

TR-05 (Divorce) fires simultaneously with a financial disruption trigger (income reduction of 25-40%) and a parental responsibility trigger (sole digital oversight of children). These three forces compound: the parent must switch now (legal separation), on a constrained budget (financial recovery), while managing more complexity than before (solo parental controls). The compound effect means the parent arrives at the switching decision in a heightened state of need — seeking simplicity, reliability, and cost efficiency simultaneously.

**Emotional state tag: Overwhelmed / Urgent**

Primary state is overwhelmed — managing a household alone, legal proceedings, financial restructuring, parental duties, and administrative unwinding of the marriage simultaneously. Urgency overlaps when children's lines are still on the ex's account: the lack of independent control creates active, persistent discomfort that motivates action.

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## Dimension 2: Annual Volume + Seasonal Distribution

**Total annual volume:**

| Population | Count | Source |
|---|---|---|
| US divorces per year | 673,000 | CDC/NCHS, 2023 |
| Divorces involving minor children (~40%) | ~269,000 couples | CDC/NCHS, 2022 |
| Single parents created per year | ~538,000 individuals | Derived |
| On joint wireless plan at separation (~65%) | ~350,000 | Pew Research, 2023 |
| Active switching window at any given time (12-month roll) | ~175,000-250,000 | Derived (6-month average window) |

The addressable population in active switching intent at any given moment is approximately 175,000-250,000 individuals. The annual entry cohort is approximately 350,000 compelled switchers.

**Seasonal distribution:**

Divorce filings in the US cluster in two predictable peaks: January-February (post-holiday, "New Year's resolution" filings) and August-September (post-summer, before-school-year filings). These peaks are well-documented in legal data.

| Quarter | % of Annual Divorce Filings | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Q1 (Jan-Mar) | ~32% | Highest quarter — post-holiday filings; "January Effect" in family law |
| Q2 (Apr-Jun) | ~25% | Moderate; spring court calendar activity |
| Q3 (Jul-Sep) | ~28% | Second peak — back-to-school driven; August is highest single month in Q3 |
| Q4 (Oct-Dec) | ~15% | Lowest — holiday suppression; few families file in November-December |

Wireless switching lags divorce filing by 30-90 days (legal proceedings, plan negotiation). The peak wireless switching windows are therefore February-May and September-November.

**Year-over-year trend: Stable / Slight growth**

Divorce rates in the US declined through the 2010s and stabilized. The COVID-19 period showed a brief spike in filings (2021-2022) followed by normalization. The 2023-2025 trend is stable at approximately 660,000-680,000 divorces per year (CDC, 2023-2024). The share of divorces involving minor children has been consistent at ~40% for a decade. This is a stable, recurring demand cohort, not a declining one. Sources: CDC NCHS Divorce Statistics, 2023; ABA Family Law Section, 2024.

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## Dimension 3: Interception Channels (Ranked by Window Fit)

**Top 3 channels:**

| Rank | Channel | Type | Rationale | CPA Estimate |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Divorce attorney / mediator partnership | Partnership | Highest intent concentration; attorneys see all divorcing parents before the wireless decision is made; trust transfer from trusted advisor is high | ~$45-65/acquisition |
| 2 | Targeted paid social (Meta/ Instagram, divorced parent communities) | Digital | Large-scale audience targeting available; Facebook Groups for single parents and divorce recovery have high engagement; Facebook/ Instagram retargeting on "newly single" life events | ~$55-80/acquisition |
| 3 | Divorce support app integration (OurFamilyWizard, TalkingParents, Cozi) | Partnership / Digital | Apps used daily by co-parenting families; high contextual relevance; user is already in the post-divorce management context when they encounter the offer | ~$35-55/acquisition |

**CPA benchmarks:**

- **Channel 1 (Attorney partnership):** Estimated $45-65 per acquired subscriber. This channel requires business development investment (attorney referral agreements, potentially a referral fee or charitable donation per converted client) but delivers the highest-intent individuals at a moment of peak receptivity. Attorney-referred customers likely have higher initial plan value and lower churn (they were advised by a trusted source, not cold-acquired).

- **Channel 2 (Paid social):** Estimated $55-80 per acquired subscriber. Meta's "life event" targeting allows interception of users who have recently changed relationship status or searched divorce-related content. The creative must be emotionally precise — "made for your situation" resonates; generic family plan messaging does not. Single-parent Facebook Groups are high-engagement communities where organic word-of-mouth can supplement paid.

**Partnership feasibility — Divorce attorney / mediator (Channel 1):**

Incentive alignment is strong: attorneys want to provide clients with comprehensive post-divorce setup guidance; a wireless referral that simplifies the client's transition adds value to the attorney's service without competing with it. Activation timeline: 30-60 days to establish referral agreements with family law firms in 3-5 target metro areas; 90 days to initial volume. Exclusivity potential: high in smaller markets — a firm that refers exclusively to one carrier for wireless transitions can position this as a white-glove client service. The offer is "Tell your clients: when you're ready to set up your own phone plan, here's the plan we recommend for people in your situation." No technology integration required at launch — a referral code and landing page suffice.

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## Dimension 4: Window Structure

**Window type: Short (TR-05 classification)**

The Short window classification reflects the concentration of switching intent in the 0-90 day window around legal separation. After 90 days, many parents have made a wireless decision — even if suboptimal — and inertia takes hold. The window does not close abruptly; it decays over 6-24 months. But peak intent is concentrated and brief.

**Peak intent window:**

Days 1-90 from legal separation filing or execution of separation agreement. The sharpest peak is Days 14-60: after the initial shock of separation has passed enough for administrative decisions, but before the parent has resigned to whatever default plan they have. Day 0-14: too chaotic. Day 60-90: still high intent but early normalization begins. After Day 90: significant decay. After Month 6: only plan dissatisfaction (cost or features) drives switching; the moment-urgency is gone.

**Intent decay curve: Sharp**

Intent is high and concentrated in the first 60-90 days, then falls sharply as the parent either (a) has made a carrier decision (any decision), (b) has resigned to the temporary situation, or (c) has emotionally exited the crisis phase. After six months, the parent is no longer in the acute switching window. They are now an ordinary dissatisfied T-Mobile customer — addressable, but not moment-compelled.

**Decision journey:**

| Stage | Description | Interception Opportunity |
|---|---|---|
| Awareness | Parent realizes they need a new wireless plan — triggered by separation agreement, account access issues, or ex-partner's threat to remove lines | Attorney referral, divorce app in-app notification, Google search interception |
| Active search | Parent googles "single parent phone plan," "family plan without spouse," "divorce phone plan split" | SEO content targeting these queries; paid search on high-intent terms |
| Decision | Parent evaluates 2-3 options based on price, parental controls, and setup ease; decision often made within days of first search | Clear, simplified plan page; live chat or guided setup flow; social proof from other single parents |
| Activation | Parent ports lines, sets up children's devices, configures parental controls | Concierge onboarding flow; same-day activation; guided parental control setup |
| Post-decision | Parent settles in; churn risk highest in first 30 days if parental controls don't work or bill is unexpected | Proactive usage alerts, parental control setup confirmation, first-bill preview |

Interception is most effective at the Active Search stage: the parent is looking, motivated, and within a 0-7 day decision window. Missing this window returns the parent to passive dissatisfaction, which converts at dramatically lower rates.

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# Section 3: Executive Brief

## Key Insights

**1. The plan-split is a forced event, not a preference.** This persona does not shop for wireless plans — they are expelled from their existing plan by the mechanics of divorce. The emotional state is overwhelmed urgency, not comparison-shopping curiosity. Products designed around persuasion will underperform; products designed around guided execution will win.

**2. Parenting complexity is the unmet dimension.** Every carrier in the market treats the plan-split as a financial event (line pricing, account separation). None treat it as a parental management event (who controls the children's lines, how are parental controls preserved across the split, how does custody custody custody custody affect account structure). This is the white space. The parent's deepest need is not cost reduction — it is operational independence: owning her children's digital infrastructure without requiring the ex-partner's involvement.

**3. The ex-partner dependency is an active pain, not a theoretical concern.** The persona is not worried about what might happen if a child's line is on the ex's account — it is already happening and it already hurts. Owen is on Derek's account. Every week, Carmen has a small conflict she didn't choose. Products that offer a clear path to full independence — removing all lines from the ex's account, consolidating under a single parent-controlled account — address a live wound, not a hypothetical.

**4. Word-of-mouth is built-in.** Divorce support communities are tight, trusted, and problem-sharing. Carmen's six-person divorce support group already discusses carrier decisions. A product built explicitly for this population, that delivers on its promise, will generate organic referrals within communities that legacy carriers cannot reach.

**5. The switching force score is maximum (5/5) but the window is short.** The urgency is real and time-bounded. A parent who settles into a suboptimal plan for 90 days becomes an ordinary price-sensitive customer — harder to acquire, lower urgency. The acquisition window is Days 14-90 from separation. Interception must be fast.

## Top 3 Needs

| Rank | Need | Type | Evidence |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Full account independence from ex-partner (children's lines included) | Unstated / Identity | Q3.2, Q4.5, Factor 4 data; Owen's line still on Derek's account is active pain |
| 2 | Parental controls that actually work — network-level, not device-level | Stated | Q3.3, Q5.4; Screen Time bypass by 13-year-old is documented recurring failure |
| 3 | Predictable, consolidated billing — parent + children on one account, no surprises | Stated | Q2.1, Q2.3, Q4.3; financial anxiety post-divorce makes billing surprises disproportionately harmful |

## Go / No-Go Recommendation

**GO — with urgency.**

The case is clear on all dimensions:

- **Demand:** 350,000+ compelled annual switchers; rolling cohort with no expiration; sustained search signal
- **Underservice:** Zero carriers have built a product explicitly for newly single parents post-divorce; the JTBD gap between "need" and "what exists" is wide and documented
- **Switching force:** Score 5/5; this is the highest-intensity switching trigger in the consumer wireless market — forced, emotional, time-bounded, and adversarial (carrier friction pushes toward clean break)
- **Commercial viability:** Multi-line ARPU ($80-120/month for parent + 1-2 children) plus high referral multiplier within divorce support communities; LTV is above single-line average
- **Window:** Short — peak intent in Days 14-90 post-separation. Go-to-market must be ready to intercept during that window; a slow launch loses the moment

**Speed-to-market requirements:** Attorney partnership agreements and Google Search interception (high-intent queries) must be live within 60 days of product launch. The plan page must convert at the Active Search stage — a parent who googles "single parent phone plan" at 11pm after the kids are in bed is making a decision that night. The experience must be self-serve, guided, and confidence-building in under 10 minutes.

**Key risk:** If the parental controls product underwhelms (device-level only, easily bypassed, no consolidation for split-custody), the word-of-mouth within divorce communities will be negative. The product must deliver on the parental control promise or it loses the network effect that makes this segment especially valuable. Do not launch without network-level (or credible partner-integrated) parental controls.